

Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work

Every quiz answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab — for all eight modules. Use for grading and reteaching. Confidential instructor material.

8 modules

every quiz item + lab reference notes

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Module 0: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for the lab: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lesson 1

6 quiz items

1 guided build + independent pass

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-check items use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "Q3" is always this key's Q3. The lesson pages themselves don't carry quizzes; these items were written for the kit and test only what L01 teaches.

L01 • FIX & EXPORT ONE PHOTO

Q1

What does non-destructive editing mean?

B) Making changes on layers above the photo, so the original pixels are never altered

Why: The tracing-paper idea: changes live on sheets (layers) you can toggle, tweak, or peel off. A) confuses "non-destructive" with "subtle"; a big edit on an adjustment layer is still non-destructive. C) is still editing pixels directly, just on a copy.

Q2

Why do you choose File ► Save As and the .psd format right after opening your photo?

B) A .psd remembers your layers so you can change your mind, and your original JPEG stays untouched

Why: This is the tracing-paper principle applied to the file itself. A .psd is usually *larger* than a JPEG (A is wrong), and Photoshop opens JPEGs fine (C is wrong); a JPEG simply can't store layers.

Q3

With the Crop tool active, how do you straighten a tilted horizon?

A) Move the cursor just outside a corner until it becomes a bent arrow, then drag to rotate until the grid lines match the horizon

Why: Straightening is rotating the crop grid to agree with a line that should be level. Dragging a corner inward (B) only trims edges; dragging inside the box (C) repositions the image.

Q4

You click the eyeball next to your Brightness/Contrast layer and the whole effect disappears. What does that tell you?

C) The edit lives on the adjustment layer, not in the photo itself

Why: This is "the magic moment" from the lesson: non-destructive editing you can see. Nothing failed (A), and the photo was never permanently changed (B).

Q5

What's the difference between Save and Export?

B) Save writes your layered .psd so you can keep editing; Export flattens everything into a share-ready .jpg

Why: You do both, for different reasons, every time: the .psd is the editable master, the .jpg is the copy you share. Never post the .psd; never edit on the .jpg.

Q6

You can't find the Layers panel anywhere on screen. What do you do?

A) Choose Window ► Layers (or press F7)

Why: Every panel lives in the Window menu. (Resetting the workspace with Window ► Workspace also brings panels back, but the direct fix is Window ► Layers.)

LAB REFERENCE: GUIDED BUILD (L01-TILTED-HORIZON.JPG OR OWN PHOTO)

A correct result looks like: two files. `myphoto-working.psd` opens with two layers: the photo at the bottom and a **Brightness/Contrast** adjustment layer above it; toggling that layer's eyeball shows a clear before/after. `myphoto-final.jpg` is cropped (the dark blob in the practice file's bottom-left corner is gone), the horizon is level (within about half a degree to the eye), and shadows are more open with a little more punch. The original `.jpg` is unchanged on disk.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Only one layer in the .psd, but the photo is brighter.** The learner used Image ► Adjustments (a direct, destructive edit) instead of the  button in the Layers panel. Show them the  button and redo Step 3.
- ◆ **Horizon tilted the other way, or still tilted.** They rotated in the wrong direction or estimated by eye without lining a grid line up with the horizon. Have them rotate until one horizontal grid line sits exactly on it.
- ◆ **Crop is a perfect square or odd shape.** The Crop tool's ratio menu was set from a previous use. Click **Clear** in the options bar and redo.
- ◆ **No .psd anywhere, or the .psd has no adjustment layer.** They skipped Save As, or skipped the final **File ► Save** before exporting, so the .psd only holds the state from Step 1.
- ◆ **Original photo was overwritten.** They exported with the original's name into the same folder. Lesson learned: always export as `-final.jpg`.
- ◆ **Washed-out, flat-gray result.** Brightness pushed very high with no Contrast. "Nudge" both; this file needs a moderate lift, not the maximum.

LAB REFERENCE: INDEPENDENT PASS (LEARNER'S OWN PHOTO, OR L01-T00-BRIGHT.JPG)

Own photos vary, so judge the **process**, not a specific look: a .psd saved before editing, at least one adjustment layer that toggles cleanly, a new-name export, and an original left untouched. With the lesson's too-bright twist, **a correct result looks like:** a .psd with **two** adjustment layers above the photo (Brightness/Contrast with Brightness lowered slightly, and Vibrance with Vibrance raised gently), plus an exported .jpg. Colors look richer without neon edges; highlights have a little more detail than the original.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Garish, neon colors.** Saturation was pushed instead of (or as well as) Vibrance, or Vibrance went to the maximum. Vibrance is the gentler control; "gently" is the lesson's word.
- ◆ **Only one adjustment layer.** They edited the existing Brightness/Contrast layer again instead of clicking ● a second time. The point of the exercise is seeing two sheets of tracing paper.
- ◆ **A visibly worse result than the original.** Usually a dark photo darkened further or a bright one brightened: the learner copied the demo's slider direction instead of looking at their own photo. Ask "what does *this* photo need?" and let them fix it on the same layer (that's the point of adjustment layers).
- ◆ **"Reordering changed nothing."** A valid observation: with these two adjustments the difference is often subtle. The going-further question is about curiosity, not a specific answer.

Module 1: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 2–4

18 quiz items

3 guided builds + 3 solo variations

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-check items use the same question numbers as this key. The lesson pages themselves don't carry quizzes; these items were written for the kit and test only what L02–L04 teach.

L02 • THE LAYER STACK & YOUR FIRST MASK

Q1

In the stack-of-glass model, what happens where a higher layer is opaque?

B) It covers what's below it

Why: "Higher layers win where they're opaque." Clear glass lets lower sheets show through; opaque paint on a higher sheet hides them. That's also why order is meaning.

Q2

You paint black on an adjustment layer's mask. What happens in that area?

A) The adjustment is hidden there, and the original shows through

Why: Black hides, white reveals. Painting on a mask never paints the photo (B); it only controls how much of this layer's effect gets through, so it can't make the effect stronger than full (C).

Q3

You selected the mask, pressed **Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace** to fill it black, and nothing changed. Why?

C) That shortcut fills with the background color, which was white

Why: **Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace/Delete** fills with the *background* color. Use **Alt/⌥ + Backspace/Delete** with black as the foreground color, or **Edit ► Fill... ► Contents: Black**.

Q4

While painting white to reveal the sky, you painted over part of the land by mistake. What's the best fix?

B) Press X to switch to black and paint over the mistake

Why: Masks make mistakes painless: you're only adjusting a stencil, so you can go back and forth forever. Starting over (A) wastes the work; the Eraser on the photo (C) is destructive and doesn't touch the mask at all.

Q5

An adjustment layer shows two thumbnails. Which should you click before painting, as a habit?

A) The mask thumbnail (the white/black card)

Why: On an adjustment layer the brush lands on the mask anyway (it has no pixels of its own), but the habit matters on pixel layers with masks, where the image thumbnail being selected means you paint the photo itself. Clicking the photo layer (C) is the classic way to paint on the picture by accident.

Q6

Your masked edit has a hard, obvious line at the horizon. What went wrong, and how do you fix it?

C) The brush was too hard; lower Hardness and paint the seam at low opacity

Why: Soft edges make believable masks. Right-click the canvas to reach Hardness, and blend the seam at about 30% opacity: that's "painting gray," a partial reveal.

LAB REFERENCE: RESCUE THE SKY (L02-WASHED-SKY.JPG OR OWN LANDSCAPE)

A correct result looks like: sky-rescue-working.psd with two layers: the photo, and one Brightness/Contrast layer (Brightness pulled down) above it. The mask thumbnail is black over the land and white over the sky, with a soft gray band along the horizon. In sky-rescue-final.jpg the sky is noticeably deeper and cloud shapes are easier to see; the hills and tree look exactly as they did in the original.

Common wrong results and why:

- **White or black streaks painted onto the image.** The photo layer was active, so the brush painted real pixels. Undo, click the adjustment layer's mask thumbnail, repaint.
- **Whole photo darkened, mask still all white.** The fill step was skipped or used Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace (background color = white).
- **Sky only faintly darker, even where fully painted.** Brush opacity was left at 30% from seam work, or the foreground wasn't pure white (press D).
- **A hard ridge or a dark band along the horizon.** Hard brush, or the darkening spilled onto the hilltops. Soft brush at low opacity; press X and paint black to pull it back off the land.
- **Land looks right but the sky looks gray and muddy.** Brightness pulled too far. The fix is the slider, not the mask: the adjustment stays editable.

LAB REFERENCE: SPOTLIGHT (L02-SPOTLIGHT-OBJECT.JPG OR OWN PORTRAIT/OBJECT)

A correct result looks like: two adjustment layers above the photo: a brightening one whose mask is black except for a white subject-shape, and a darkening one whose mask is white over the background and black over the subject. The subject reads as gently lit and the background recedes. Going further: after Ctrl/⌘ + I the white and black swap, so the brightening moves to the background (the learner should describe the flip).

Common wrong results: both masks painted over the same area (the effects cancel out), a visible "cutout" outline around the subject from a hard brush, or a single layer adjusted twice instead of two layers.

L03 · SELECTIONS THAT HOLD UP

Q1

What's the difference between a selection and a mask?

C) A selection is a temporary request; a mask is the saved, editable answer

Why: Marching ants vanish when you deselect or click elsewhere. Converted to a mask, the same boundary is written down as white (inside) and black (outside), and you can paint on it later. B has the two backwards; the lesson FAQ calls them "cousins," not the same thing (A).

Q2

On a busy photo, Select Subject grabbed the wrong thing. What should you try?

B) Use the Object Selection tool and draw a box around exactly the thing you want

Why: Select Subject guesses the most prominent subject. The Object Selection tool lets you point: it snaps to the object inside your box. The Eraser (C) destroys pixels.

Q3

With the Quick Selection tool, how do you subtract background that got included?

A) Hold Alt/⌘ while you paint over it

Why: Paint to add, Alt/⌘-paint to subtract. Pressing Delete (C) would erase the selected pixels, the exact habit this lesson avoids.

Q4

Your subject's hair edges look chunky. Which tool rebuilds fine strands?

C) The Refine Edge Brush in Select & Mask, painted along the hairline

Why: It's built specifically to reconstruct fine strands; a normal brush can't (A). Paint along the hairline, not the solid interior.

Q5

In Select & Mask, which Output To setting keeps your cutout non-destructive in this lesson's build?

B) Layer Mask

Why: Output To: Layer Mask saves the answer as an editable mask on your photo layer. (If Decontaminate Colors is checked, Photoshop switches to New Layer with Layer Mask, which is also non-destructive: the original layer is kept, just hidden.) Deleting (A) destroys pixels.

Q6

Your cutout has a bright halo and a colored fringe from the old background. What helps?

A) Shift Edge slightly negative, plus Decontaminate Colors

Why: Shift Edge slightly negative bites off leftover background; Decontaminate Colors removes the colored fringe. A razor-sharp edge (C) is itself a tell-tale sign of a bad cutout; a believable edge is slightly soft.

LAB REFERENCE: CUT OUT A SUBJECT (`L03-SUBJECT-BUSY-BG.JPG` **OR OWN PHOTO)**

A correct result looks like: `cutout-working.psd` with the subject layer carrying a layer mask (white subject silhouette on black) and a calm background layer beneath it (`L03-calm-background.jpg` or a solid fill). No bright halo, no razor-sharp edge. Shift-clicking the mask thumbnail brings the busy background back instantly, proof nothing was deleted.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Background layer is transparent checkerboard, no mask.** The learner pressed Delete on the selection. Undo (or reopen the original) and redo with Output To: Layer Mask.
- ◆ **Marching ants but no mask after OK.** Output To was left on Selection.
- ◆ **Calm background covers the subject.** The new layer was created above. Drag it below, or Ctrl/⌘-click the New Layer icon next time. If it won't go below, the photo is still a locked Background layer: click its lock first.
- ◆ **Thin light outline around the subject.** Halo: Shift Edge slightly negative, a touch of Feather, Decontaminate Colors.
- ◆ **Bits of the busy background left inside the subject shape.** Step 2 was skipped. Paint black on the mask to hide them (or Alt/⌘-subtract before refining).

LAB REFERENCE: HARDER SUBJECT (`L03-FUZZY-SUBJECT.JPG` **ONTO** `L03-OTHER-SCENE.JPG` **, OR OWN HAIR/FUR/PLANT PHOTO)**

A correct result looks like: the wispy fibers survive as soft, slightly translucent strands over the new background instead of being chopped into a smooth blob; little or no green fringe from the original background. A clash in color or light between subject and new background is expected and should be noted, not fixed: that's Module 4. Going further: after Select ► Inverse, the *background* is selected.

Common wrong results: a smooth, "helmet" edge (Refine Edge Brush not used, or used on the solid center); strands with a green cast (Decontaminate Colors off); strands missing because Smooth was pushed high.

L04 · CLEANING UP: SPOTS, DISTRACTIONS & EDGES

Q1

What's the difference between healing and cloning?

B) Healing blends the borrowed texture's color and brightness into its surroundings; cloning copies pixels exactly

Why: Both borrow good pixels; they differ in how they blend. Heal to blend, clone to copy. Neither is limited to skin or skies (A), and neither needs a selection (C): Content-Aware Fill is the one that does.

Q2

Why do all your cleanup on a separate, empty **retouch** layer?

C) The original photo is never touched, and a bad heal can simply be erased off that layer

Why: It's the Module 0 tracing-paper principle applied to retouching. The tools work on any layer (A), and the export is flattened into one image anyway, so an extra layer doesn't make the JPEG smaller (B).

Q3

You click a dust spot with the Spot Healing Brush on your empty **retouch** layer, and nothing happens. What's the likely cause?

A) Sample All Layers is unchecked in the options bar

Why: Without it, the tool samples only the empty layer, so there's nothing to borrow. Zooming to 100% (B) and a brush slightly larger than the spot (C) are both what the lesson recommends.

Q4

A pole stands right against a building's straight, hard roofline. Following the decision tree, which tool is best for the part along that edge?

C) Clone Stamp

Why: Hard edges, straight lines, and patterns call for copying the structure exactly. Healing tools blend with whatever's nearby and smear hard edges (A); a huge content-aware selection (B) invites smears and repeats.

Q5

On your **retouch** layer, the Clone Stamp paints nothing at all. What do you do?

B) Set the Clone Stamp's Sample: menu to Current & Below, then Alt/⌘-click a clean source

Why: The Clone Stamp's Sample: menu is a separate setting from the Spot Healing Brush's checkbox (A); on the default Current Layer it samples the empty layer. Cloning directly on the photo (C) breaks the non-destructive habit.

Q6

How do you know a photo is "clean enough"?

A) One pass at 100% zoom, then view it fit-to-screen: if nothing pulls your eye from the subject, you're done

Why: Straight from the lesson FAQ. Perfect at 400% that no one will ever see is wasted effort (B), and there's no need to use every tool (C).

LAB REFERENCE: CLEAN & EXPORT (`L04-DUSTY-SKY.JPG` OR OWN PHOTO)

A correct result looks like: `cleanup-working.psd` with the untouched photo, a `retouch` layer holding the spot heals, Remove-tool work, and clone strokes (toggling its eyeball brings the dust spots back), and possibly a separate Content-Aware Fill output layer. In `cleanup-final.jpg`, at 100%: all dust spots in the sky are gone, the bird and the pole with its wire are gone with no obvious smear or repeated shape, and the rooftop edge beside the pole is still straight and crisp.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Retouch layer is empty; the fixes are on the photo.** The photo layer was active. It still looks fine, but it isn't non-destructive: redo on the retouch layer if time allows, and name it in feedback.
- ◆ **A few spots remain.** The learner worked zoomed out or not methodically. Zoom to 100% and scan left to right, top to bottom.
- ◆ **Soft gray smudge where the pole was, or a wavy roofline.** A healing or content-aware tool blended a hard edge. Clone Stamp along the edge.
- ◆ **A cloud or the bird appears twice.** Content-aware repeat. Redo with a smaller selection, or clone out the remnant.
- ◆ **Content-Aware Fill produced nothing, or an error.** The empty retouch layer was active or there was no selection. Click the photo layer, select, then run it.

LAB REFERENCE: TWO WAYS (`L04-PHOTOBOMB.JPG` OR OWN PHOTO)

A correct result looks like: the trash can and the figure removed twice, once per method (on separate layers or in two saved versions), with a comparison filled in. There's no single right "winner": on the practice file's plain sand and sea, both usually work; a good answer names the tell-tale signs actually found (smear, repeat, halo) and what fixed them. Going further (combining L03 + L04) is optional.

Common wrong results: removing the object only once; judging at fit-to-screen instead of 100%; cloning with Current Layer sampling and concluding "the Clone Stamp doesn't work."

Module 2: Answers & Lab Notes

Every self-check answered and explained, reference answers for the write-in exercises, and lab notes: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 5-7

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The course lessons have no built-in quizzes, so the self-checks were written for this kit from each lesson's content. The workbook and this key use the same question numbers, so a learner's "L06 Q3" is always this key's L06 Q3.

L05 • THE DEVELOP STEP: CAMERA RAW (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

Why convert the layer to a Smart Object before choosing Filter ► Camera Raw Filter?

B) So Camera Raw is applied as a re-editable Smart Filter you can reopen and change any time

Why: On a Smart Object, the filter is an instruction on the container, so every slider stays live. A is a common misconception: the filter does run on a normal layer, but there it bakes in. C is false; Smart Objects usually make files a little *larger*.

Q2

An indoor photo has orange-looking whites. What's the fastest first move in Camera Raw?

A) Click the White Balance eyedropper on something that should be neutral gray or white

Why: The eyedropper tells Camera Raw "this should have no color," and the cast snaps away. Then fine-tune Temperature and Tint. Exposure and Contrast change brightness, not color.

Q3

Which order does the develop pass follow?

C) White Balance → Exposure → Contrast → Highlights/Shadows → Whites/Blacks

Why: The lesson works the panel top to bottom: color first, then overall brightness, then the ends of the range. Setting Whites/Blacks before Exposure means redoing them after Exposure moves everything.

Q4

What does holding Alt/⌘ while dragging the Whites or Blacks slider show you?

A) Where the image is clipping: pure white or pure black with no detail left

Why: The preview turns into a clipping map so you can push Whites until just shy of clipping and Blacks until there's a true black. A little clipping is fine (a specular reflection should be white).

Q5

What does "global before local" mean?

B) Fix the whole image first (white balance, overall tone), then make selective local tweaks

Why: Local work on a photo that still has a cast is "polishing a problem." Get the base honest first; masked, local adjustments come after (L06).

Q6

You only have a JPEG, not a RAW file. Can you still do the develop step?

C) Yes, the Camera Raw Filter runs on any layer; RAW just gives more room to recover highlights and shadows

Why: Straight from the lesson's FAQ: Filter ► Camera Raw Filter works on JPEG, PNG, anything. The workflow is identical; RAW files simply have more latitude.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: MATCH THE PROBLEM TO THE SLIDER

Orange whites → **White Balance eyedropper** (then Temperature). Too dark overall → **Exposure**. Blown-out sky → **Highlights** down (Whites if needed). Muddy shadows → **Shadows** up. Flat and hazy → **Contrast** (and deliberate Whites/Blacks). No true black → **Blacks** down. Accept reasonable alternatives if the learner can explain them.

LAB NOTES: DEVELOP A FLAT PHOTO

Correct result: the layer thumbnail shows the Smart Object page badge; Camera Raw Filter is listed under "Smart Filters" beneath it. On `105-flat-cast.jpg` the gray card and white wall read neutral, the sky reads blue rather than teal or orange, the darkest shadow under the roof is near black, and the white wall has detail but is bright. File saved as `grade-working.psd`.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **No Smart Filter in the Layers panel.** They skipped Convert to Smart Object, so Camera Raw baked into the pixels. Fix: undo, convert, redo.
- ◆ **Photo turned blue or magenta.** The eyedropper was clicked on something that isn't neutral (the orange-lit wall, skin, the sky). Re-click on the gray card or white wall.
- ◆ **Still hazy after Contrast.** Whites and Blacks weren't set. A hazy image usually has no true black; drag Blacks down with the Alt/⌘ preview.
- ◆ **Large pure-white areas in the sky.** Whites or Exposure pushed too far. Pull Highlights down and back Whites off until the clipping map shows only specks.
- ◆ **Looks right on the projector, green on the laptop (or vice versa).** A screen problem, not an editing problem. Judge on the learner's own screen with Night Light / True Tone off.

L06 · CURVES: PRECISE TONE & COLOR (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

On an untouched Curves graph, what does the straight diagonal line mean?

A) Every tone leaves exactly as it came in: no change

Why: Input across, output up. On the diagonal, output equals input for every tone. The mantra: "the diagonal is leave it alone."

Q2

A photo looks flat and hazy. Which curve adds contrast?

C) An S-curve: the shadows point dragged down, the highlights point dragged up

Why: Pulling shadows darker and highlights brighter spreads the tones apart; the steeper middle is more contrast. A only brightens; B fades the blacks, which *reduces* contrast.

Q3

What does lifting the bottom-left corner (the black end) of the curve do?

B) Gives "milky," faded blacks for a matte or vintage look

Why: The darkest input now outputs as dark gray, so nothing reaches true black. That's the matte grade from the lesson's table.

Q4

In the Blue channel you lift the shadow end slightly and drop the highlight end slightly. What's the result?

A) Cool (blue) shadows and warm (yellow) highlights

Why: In the Blue channel, up adds blue and down adds its opposite, yellow. Cool shadows + warm highlights is the backbone of the "teal & orange" look; pull the Red channel's shadow end down slightly for truer teal (less red = more cyan).

Q5

You added a Curves layer that brightens the photo, but you want it to affect only your subject. What next?

B) Fill its mask black, then paint white over the subject with a soft brush

Why: Black hides the adjustment everywhere; white reveals it where you paint. This is the Lesson 1.1 mask skill applied to Curves ("dodging with Curves"). A weakens it everywhere; C would damage the photo layer.

Q6

Where should your Curves adjustment layers sit relative to the Camera Raw develop?

C) Above it: develop globally first, then stack Curves on top

Why: From the lesson's FAQ. Adjustment layers affect everything below them, so they need the developed base underneath. Global before local, again.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: SKETCH THE CURVE

1 · **Brighter overall:** one point in the middle pushed up (a gentle hump above the diagonal). 2 · **More contrast:** an S: lower quarter below the diagonal, upper quarter above it. 3 · **Faded, matte blacks:** the bottom-left endpoint lifted straight up so the curve starts above the corner; usually paired with a gentle S.

LAB NOTES: CONTRAST & COLOR

Correct result: above the Camera Raw Smart Object sit two Curves layers. The first holds a gentle S-curve (and possibly small channel moves); the image has more depth but no blotchy skin or banded sky. The second is brightened and has a mostly black mask with a soft white area over one region (subject, foreground, or sky). Toggling the second layer's eye shows a subtle local lift, not a spotlight with a hard edge.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Harsh, crunchy contrast.** The S is too steep or has extra points. Two points, small moves.
- ◆ **Strong color tint everywhere.** Channel curve moved too far. A few pixels on Blue is already a strong grade.
- ◆ **Hard-edged glowing blob.** A hard brush (or 100% opacity with a small brush) painted the mask. Use a large, soft brush; lower brush opacity if needed.
- ◆ **White smears on the photo.** The image thumbnail, not the mask, was selected while painting (or they painted on the Smart Object). Undo, select the mask thumbnail.
- ◆ **The masked lift affects everything.** The mask is still white. They painted white on a white mask. Fill it black first (Alt + Backspace / ⌘ + Delete with black foreground, or Ctrl/⌘ + I).
- ◆ **Curves layers under the Smart Object.** The develop now sits on top of the Curves results. Drag the Curves layers above it.

L07 · SMART OBJECTS & FINISHING THE GRADE (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

Which is the best one-line definition of a Smart Object?

C) A container that stores your original pixels; every edit is a re-editable instruction

Why: This is the lesson's "one-line definition worth memorizing." Smart Objects don't enhance anything by themselves, and they usually add file size rather than reduce it.

Q2

You scale a layer to 30% and back to 100%. The normal layer turns mushy but the Smart Object stays crisp. Why?

B) The Smart Object re-renders from its sealed original pixels

Why: Scaling a normal layer down discards pixels permanently; scaling back up has to invent them. A Smart Object only changes the "display me at..." instruction and re-renders from the original each time.

Q3

You applied Smart Sharpen as a Smart Filter and want it on the eyes but not the skin. How?

A) Paint black on the Smart Filters mask over the skin

Why: Smart Filters carry a shared mask; black hides the filter, white reveals it. The lesson's own example is "sharpen the eyes but not the skin."

Q4

You want a Gaussian Blur Smart Filter to look like a soft glow, not a blurry photo. What do you change?

C) Double-click the filter's Blending Options icon; set Mode to Soft Light (or Screen) at about 20–40% opacity

Why: The filter's own blending options blend the blurred version with the sharp one. More radius only makes it blurrier; rasterizing would throw away the re-editability.

Q5

When should you not work on a Smart Object?

B) When healing or cloning directly on the layer's pixels

Why: Pixel-level tools need normal pixels. The lesson's pattern: retouch on normal layers first, then convert to a Smart Object for filtering and transforming. Module 3 depends on this.

Q6

You exported `module2-grade-final.jpg`. Why keep the layered .psd too?

A) The PSD is your re-editable master; the JPEG is flat and can't be re-graded

Why: The JPEG is a flattened deliverable. Every live decision (Camera Raw, Curves, Smart Filters, masks) exists only in the PSD.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: CRISP OR MUSHY, AND "IN YOUR OWN WORDS"

Crisp or mushy: the normal copy's thin lines and small text come back soft, blurry, or jagged; the Smart Object copy looks identical to the original. **Own words:** accept any answer that captures both halves: the original pixels are kept safe inside, and edits are changeable instructions (for example: "It's a sealed box around your photo. Anything you do is a note on the box you can change later, so the photo itself never gets damaged.").

LAB NOTES: FINISH THE GRADE

Correct result: the photo layer is a Smart Object with at least two Smart Filters nested beneath it (Camera Raw plus Smart Sharpen or Gaussian Blur), the Smart Filters mask shows some black where the filter is hidden, the Curves layers above are still live, and scaling down and back up left no softness. Two files exist: the layered `grade-working.psd` and `module2-grade-final.jpg` (Export As, JPG, about 80% quality).

Fake shallow depth of field (if time): on `107-subject-busy-bg.jpg`, the brick-and-dot background is soft, and the subject (and its edge) stays sharp because the filter mask is black over it.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **The blur or sharpen appears as a separate layer.** They duplicated the layer and filtered the copy, or the layer wasn't a Smart Object. Filters should nest under the Smart Object.
- ◆ **The whole photo is blurry.** Gaussian Blur applied at Normal, 100%. Use the filter's Blending Options (Soft Light or Screen, 20–40%) for a glow, or mask it.
- ◆ **Soft after the scale test.** They scaled a normal layer, or rasterized the Smart Object. Check the thumbnail badge.
- ◆ **A mystery tab opened.** They double-clicked the Smart Object thumbnail (which opens its contents). Close that tab without saving changes.
- ◆ **Only a JPEG exists.** They exported but never saved the PSD, so nothing is re-editable. Save the master first, then Export As.

Module 3: Answers & Lab Notes

Every self-check answered and explained, reference answers for the write-in exercises, and lab notes: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 8–10

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The course lessons have no built-in quizzes, so the self-checks were written for this kit from each lesson's content. The workbook and this key use the same question numbers.

GRADING PORTRAIT WORK

Grade the *edit*, never the subject's appearance. Written and spoken feedback should name a technique ("the heal on the left cheek picked up a shadow"), not a feature of the person.

L08 • NATURAL SKIN: HEAL, DON'T ERASE (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

Using the temporary-vs-permanent test, which one should you heal?

C) A red spot that wasn't there last week

Why: It wouldn't be there next week, so it's temporary. Freckles and laugh lines are permanent: part of who the person is. Keep them, or reduce, never erase.

Q2

Why do all the healing on a separate, empty retouch layer?

A) The original face is never touched, and the work can be reduced (opacity) or deleted later

Why: Same non-destructive idea as Module 1's cleanup. B is false (the tools work on any pixel layer; on an empty layer they just need the right sample setting); C is false.

Q3

The Healing Brush on your empty retouch layer does nothing useful. What's the likely cause?

B) Its Sample menu is on Current Layer, so it samples the empty layer; set it to Current & Below

Why: The Healing Brush uses a **Sample:** menu, separate from the Spot Healing Brush's **Sample All Layers** checkbox. On the default Current Layer it reads the empty layer. Current & Below (or All Layers) fixes it.

Q4

A blemish sits right at the hairline and the Spot Healing Brush keeps smearing hair into the skin. What's the better approach?

C) Switch to the Healing Brush and Alt/⌘-click clean skin nearby as the source

Why: Spot Healing picks its own source and can grab hair; choosing the source yourself makes a smear much less likely. If it still smears, finish with the Clone Stamp (same Sample setting). A bigger brush drags in *more* hair.

Q5

Why lower the retouch layer's opacity to about 85–90%?

A) Letting a whisper of the original through keeps the result believable

Why: A retouch that's slightly under 100% never looks too perfect. It's a finishing move, not a requirement of Photoshop.

Q6

What's the very first step of a natural retouch?

B) Survey the face at 100% and sort what you see into temporary and permanent

Why: "Decide before you act." The 60-second survey is what separates a natural result from an over-edited one. Blurring (A) is the plastic look this module avoids; C is the "clean sweep" the lesson warns against.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: SURVEY AND SORT (PRACTICE FILE)

On `108-portrait-blemishes.jpg`, **temporary (heal)**: 10 red spots in open skin (3 forehead, 5 cheeks, 2 chin), 2 red spots touching the hairline, 1 stray dark hair across the cheek on the viewer's right, 1 white lint speck on the chin. **Permanent (keep)**: the freckles across the nose bridge and upper cheeks, the brown mole beside the mouth, the two laugh lines. Use `108-flaw-map-INSTRUCTOR.png` to check. For learners' own portraits, accept any sort that follows the "next week?" test; challenge anything permanent in the heal column.

LAB NOTES: RETOUCH A PORTRAIT

Correct result: the Layers panel shows the untouched portrait with an empty-looking **retouch** layer above it (it contains only the healed patches) at about 85–90% opacity. With it on, the red spots, the stray hair, and the lint are gone; the freckles, the mole, and the laugh lines are still there. Heals are invisible at 100% zoom: no smudged hairline, no lighter or darker patches. Toggling the layer shows "the same person on a good day."

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Heals on the photo itself; retouch layer empty.** The Background stayed selected. Not fatal, but the work can't be dialed back. Redo on the retouch layer if time allows.
- ◆ **Nothing happened when clicking.** Sample All Layers unticked (Spot Healing) or Sample: Current Layer (Healing Brush) on the empty layer.
- ◆ **Freckles or the mole removed.** The "clean sweep." Delete those heals (or reduce them on a separate layer) and revisit the sort list.
- ◆ **Smudged hairline.** Spot Healing at the edge. Redo with the Healing Brush and a chosen source, or the Clone Stamp.
- ◆ **Light or dark blotch where a spot was.** Source sampled from a shadow or highlight. Re-sample from skin of the same brightness.
- ◆ **Waxy look.** Brush much larger than the spots, or repeated heals over the same area. Smaller brush, one click per spot.

L09 · FREQUENCY SEPARATION (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

In frequency separation, what does the low-frequency layer hold?

B) Color and tone: the blotches and shading

Why: Low frequency is the slow, soft stuff (the "paint"). Pores, fine hairs, and edges are high frequency (the "texture").

Q2

How much Gaussian Blur should the LOW layer get?

A) Just until the blotches are gone and the pores just disappear, no more

Why: Often around 6–12 px on a portrait, but it varies with image size, so judge by eye. Too much blur and LOW loses the face's natural shading.

Q3

For an 8-bit photo, which Apply Image settings build the HIGH layer?

C) Layer: LOW, Subtract, Scale 2, Offset 128, then set HIGH to Linear Light

Why: Subtracting the blurred copy leaves only the fine detail, centered on mid-gray; Linear Light adds it back on top of LOW. For 16-bit the recipe is Add, Scale 2, Offset 0, Invert.

Q4

Your HIGH layer is flat gray and the photo won't look normal again. What's the most likely cause?

A) HIGH's blend mode isn't set to Linear Light (or you used the wrong recipe for the bit depth)

Why: A flat gray HIGH layer is *expected* right after Apply Image; Linear Light is what makes it recombine. The lesson's FAQ names these two causes. The amount of blur on LOW changes the split, not whether it recombines.

Q5

A flyaway hair crosses the forehead. How do you remove it without shifting color?

B) Healing Brush or Clone Stamp on HIGH, with Sample: Current Layer

Why: The hair is texture, so it lives on HIGH. Sampling other layers (C) would drag color onto the texture sheet. Painting on LOW (A) only smears color; the hair's texture stays.

Q6

Why not just run a big Gaussian Blur on the whole face?

C) Blur smooths texture and color together, so the pores vanish and skin looks plastic

Why: That's the exact problem frequency separation solves: smooth one sheet without harming the other. The lesson's solo variation has learners compare the two side by side.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: RECIPE FROM MEMORY, AND HIGH-OFF

Recipe: Stamp Visible = Ctrl + Alt + Shift + E (Windows) / ⌘ + ⇧ + ⌘ + E (Mac) · the lower copy, **LOW**, is blurred · 8-bit Apply Image = **Subtract** / 2 / 128 · HIGH = **Linear Light** · blotches are evened on **LOW** · stray hair removed on **HIGH** with **Sample: Current Layer**. **HIGH-off:** with HIGH hidden, the face looks soft and blurry with no pores (pure color and shading); with it on, the texture returns on top of the evened tone.

LAB NOTES: SEPARATE & SMOOTH

Correct result: above the earlier layers sit a blurred **LOW** (Normal) and a gray-looking **HIGH** (Linear Light) on top. Before any smoothing, the image is indistinguishable from the original. After: on **109-portrait-blotchy.jpg** the reddish patches on the cheeks, nose, forehead, and chin are evened out, the fine pore grain is exactly as sharp as before, the freckles remain, and the flyaway hair on the forehead is gone with no color shift where it was. The face still has its shading (lighter center, darker sides).

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Gray mess.** Linear Light not set, Apply Image Layer not LOW, or the 8-bit recipe on a 16-bit file (or vice versa). Delete HIGH and redo.
- ◆ **Image looks slightly off before any smoothing** (halos, shifted contrast). Usually LOW and HIGH swapped, or Apply Image run on the wrong layer. Rebuild from the stamped layer.
- ◆ **Flat, shapeless face.** LOW was blurred too hard, or the smoothing was painted across the whole face. Less blur; work only on the blotchy areas.
- ◆ **Visible outlines around smoothed areas.** Lasso selection wasn't feathered. Feather 10–20 px before the small blur.
- ◆ **Plastic skin anyway.** They blurred or painted on HIGH. Texture edits on HIGH should be heal/clone only.
- ◆ **Color smudge where the hair was.** Healing on HIGH with Sample: All Layers (or Current & Below), which pulled color onto the texture sheet. Redo with Sample: Current Layer.

L10 · DODGE & BURN: SCULPTING LIGHT (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Q1

On a 50% gray layer set to Soft Light, what does painting with white do?

B) Lightens (dodges) that area

Why: In Soft Light, lighter than 50% gray lightens and darker darkens. White = dodge, black = burn. At ~10% opacity it builds up gently rather than painting white on the face.

Q2

Why use a 50% gray layer in Soft Light mode instead of an empty Normal layer?

C) 50% gray is invisible in Soft Light, so only your light and dark strokes show, and it stays re-editable

Why: On a Normal layer, white and black paint would simply cover the face. In Soft Light, the neutral gray disappears and your strokes act as light and shadow, on their own layer.

Q3

Which brush setup matches the lesson?

A) Large, soft brush at about 10% opacity, building up with many passes

Why: "Ten percent, many passes." You can always add more, but you can't un-see a harsh streak. Small, hard, or 100% brushes are the usual cause of smudgy, fake sculpting.

Q4

In your portrait the light comes from the left. How should you dodge and burn?

B) Dodge the left-facing planes and burn the right, enhancing the existing light

Why: Follow the existing light and exaggerate it a little. Evening it out (A) flattens the face; inventing new light (C) looks wrong instantly.

Q5

How does the lesson brighten the eyes and teeth?

C) A slightly brightened Curves layer with its mask filled black, then white painted over the eye whites and teeth

Why: A masked Curves layer is non-destructive and adjustable. Keep it subtle: teeth should look clean, not glowing. Pure white paint (A) looks fake; Exposure (B) brightens everything.

Q6

Why is the gray layer the pro default over the Dodge and Burn tools?

A) The tools paint directly on pixels (destructive); the gray layer stays re-editable

Why: From the lesson's FAQ. The tools are fine on a duplicate layer for a quick fix, but the gray layer wins for real work. Both tools are still in Photoshop and work in 8-bit.

EXERCISE REFERENCE: READ THE LIGHT FIRST

On `110-portrait-flat.jpg` the light comes from the **viewer's left**: the background is brighter on the left and the soft highlight sits on the left cheek. Expected plan: dodge the forehead center, the nose bridge, the tops of the cheekbones (a little more on the left), the chin; burn the right side of the face and temple, under the cheekbones, under the jaw, and the eye sockets. For learners' own portraits, accept any plan whose dodge zones sit on the side the light comes from.

LAB NOTES: SCULPT & FINISH

Correct result: a **D&B** layer in Soft Light whose thumbnail looks gray with faint white and dark marks; toggling it shows a clear but gentle gain in dimension (brighter nose bridge and cheekbone tops, deeper sides and jawline) with no visible strokes. Above it, a Curves layer with a mostly black mask and small white areas over the eye whites and teeth; on the practice file the dull, grayish eye whites and yellowish teeth look cleaner but not white-white. Two files exist: **portrait-working.psd** and **portrait-final.jpg** (Export As, JPG about 80%).

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Solid gray covering the photo.** The layer is in Normal mode. Switch it to Soft Light.
- ◆ **Strokes do nothing / look like paint.** The layer was created without the 50% gray fill, or in Normal mode on an empty layer. Remake it with Alt/⌘-click New Layer, Soft Light, and the fill checkbox.
- ◆ **Streaky, smudgy highlights.** Opacity too high or brush too small or hard. Undo and rebuild at ~10% with a big soft brush.
- ◆ **Face looks lit from two sides.** They dodged the shadow side. Burn it back; follow the original light.
- ◆ **Glowing teeth or eyes.** The Curves lift is too strong or the mask spilled onto lips and skin. Pull the curve down; paint black to clean the mask edges.
- ◆ **White and black marks directly on the face.** They painted on the portrait layer. Undo and select D&B.

Module 4 — Answers & Lab Notes

Every workbook self-check answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 11-13

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks are numbered Q1–Q6 within each lesson, so a learner's "L12 Q3" is always this key's L12 Q3. Every answer is taken from what the lesson teaches.

L11 • CUT IT OUT CLEANLY

Q1

Your cutout looked perfect on its original background but looks "pasted" on a sunset. What is the most likely cause?

B) The edge pixels still carry color from the old background (a fringe)

Why: when the subject was photographed, the edge pixels picked up color from what was behind it. The original background hides that color; a new one reveals it. Resolution (A) and blend mode (C) are not the issue.

Q2

What does Decontaminate Colors do?

B) Replaces the old background's color in the edge pixels so the edge can adopt the new scene

Why: it cleans color out of the edge rather than just choosing pixels. It is the biggest single difference between an amateur and a believable cutout.

Q3

With Decontaminate Colors ticked, which Output To setting does the lesson use?

C) New Layer with Layer Mask

Why: decontamination rewrites edge pixels, so it cannot stay fully non-destructive and Photoshop forces the result onto a new layer. The mask keeps the hiding editable, and the original layer stays underneath as a backup.

Q4

Where should you paint with the Refine Edge Brush?

B) Only on soft, wispy edges like hair and fur

Why: the brush rebuilds fine strands. Dragged across a hard edge (shoulder, jaw) it turns crisp detail to mush, and it cannot invent hair the original selection never included.

Q5

What is the lesson's "believability test" for a finished cutout?

A) Drop a saturated colored layer behind it and check whether a fringe appears

Why: if the edge stays clean against a wild color, it will stay clean against any real scene. If a fringe appears, raise the decontamination Amount. Zooming out (B) hides the problem.

Q6

What is the keyboard shortcut for Select and Mask?

C) Ctrl+Alt+R / ⌘+⌘+R

Why: Ctrl/⌘+J duplicates a layer (or copies a selection to a new layer); Ctrl/⌘+Alt/⌘+G creates a clipping mask (Lesson 12). Select and Mask is also on the Select menu and the options bar of any selection tool.

LAB REFERENCE: A COMPOSITE-READY CUTOUT

A correct result: a group named **SUBJECT** containing a new layer with a layer mask; the original photo layer is present and hidden beneath; against a saturated Solid Color fill the hair edge shows fine, soft strands and no colored halo; solid edges (shoulders, clothing) are crisp. File saved as **composite-working.psd**. On **l11-figure-on-green.png**, the green halo around the hair and shoulders should be gone at 200% zoom.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Green (or blue) halo still visible:** Decontaminate Colors not ticked, or Amount too low. Re-enter Select and Mask on the original layer and raise Amount.
- ◆ **Mushy shoulders or jaw:** the Refine Edge Brush was run over hard edges. Redo the refinement, brushing hair only.
- ◆ **Whole outline soft and glowing:** Smooth or Feather set high. Return them to 0 or near it.
- ◆ **Chunky, helmet-like hair:** Refine Hair / Smart Radius skipped, or the initial selection missed the hair mass. Improve the selection, then brush.
- ◆ **No backup:** the background was deleted rather than masked, or the original layer was thrown away. Explain why it matters: decontamination is destructive to the edge pixels.

L12 · MAKE IT BELONG: MATCH LIGHT & COLOR

Q1

In what order does the lesson match a subject to a scene?

A) Brightness, then color, then contrast

Why: most "bad composite" feelings come from brightness alone, so fixing it first often does eighty percent of the work. Following the order keeps you from chasing your own tail.

Q2

What does clipping an adjustment layer do?

C) Limits the adjustment to the one layer directly below it

Why: an unclipped adjustment changes everything beneath it, including the background you are trying to match. Clipping uses the subject's own shape to contain the adjustment, with no mask painting needed.

Q3

Which shortcut clips the active layer to the layer below?

B) Ctrl+Alt+G / ⌘+⇧+G

Why: alternatively, hold Alt/⇧ and click the line between the two layers. Ctrl/⌘+T is Free Transform; Ctrl/⌘+Shift+N makes a new layer.

Q4

You warmed your subject evenly for a sunset and now it looks "dipped in orange." What does the lesson suggest?

B) Add a touch of the opposite (cooler) temperature to the shadow side

Why: warm light usually means cool shadows. The lit side should catch the scene's warm light; the shadow side gets a touch of the opposite temperature for realism.

Q5

Why convert the SUBJECT group to a Smart Object before scaling it?

A) So resizing never degrades it

Why: a Smart Object re-renders from its original contents each time you transform it, so repeated resizing does not soften it (scaling past its original pixel size still does). It does not block adjustments (B) or match color automatically (C).

Q6

How can you judge a scene's color temperature, according to the lesson?

C) Read the highlights and shadows on existing objects, or sample a neutral surface with the eyedropper

Why: warm highlights and cool shadows mean warm light. Sampling a neutral surface in the scene gives you the exact cast to match.

LAB REFERENCE: MATCH THE SUBJECT

A correct result: layer stack (top to bottom) of clipped adjustments (Curves, Color Balance, and optionally Hue/Saturation, each showing ↵), the **SUBJECT** Smart Object with its name underlined, and the background scene. The subject is sized for its spot in the scene with its feet on the ground. When squinting, it does not pop out as brighter than its neighbors. On **l12-scene-sunset.jpg** the subject's lit (right) side is warm orange-gold and its shadow side is slightly cooler; saturation is a little lower than the original cutout. Toggling the clipped layers off makes the subject look obviously pasted.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **The sky or ground changed color too:** an adjustment is not clipped. Clip it.
- ◆ **Subject still glows against the scene:** color was adjusted but brightness never was. Go back to step 1 and squint.
- ◆ **Uniformly orange subject:** warmth applied everywhere, including the shadows. Cool the shadow tones a touch in Color Balance.
- ◆ **Soft, blurry subject:** it was scaled several times before being converted to a Smart Object, or scaled far beyond its original size.
- ◆ **Floating giant:** scale and placement ignore perspective; compare to nearby objects and put the feet on the ground plane.

L13 · GROUND IT & GRADE IT

Q1

According to the lesson, what is the strongest single cue that a subject belongs in a scene?

B) A contact shadow where the subject meets the ground

Why: nothing real floats. The first dark sliver of shadow at the contact point is what sells contact; the cast shadow, haze, and grade add to it.

Q2

Why do the contact shadow and the cast shadow go on separate layers?

A) So you can blur the cast shadow without softening the contact point

Why: the contact shadow must stay tight and dark and is never blurred; the cast shadow gets softer as it travels, so it alone gets Gaussian Blur.

Q3

The sun in your background is high and to the right. Which way should your subject's cast shadow fall?

C) Low-left, away from the sun

Why: shadows fall away from the light. There is one sun, so every shadow in the scene must fall the same way; check the background's existing shadows and match them.

Q4

Compared with nearby things, how do distant things look in a real scene?

B) Hazier, lighter, and lower in contrast

Why: air is not perfectly clear. That atmospheric perspective is what a low-opacity haze layer recreates for a mid or far subject.

Q5

Where does the unifying grade go in the layer stack?

A) At the very top, over everything

Why: because it sits over both subject and background, it forces them to share one final look, the way a single camera would. Clipped to the subject (B) it would do the opposite: separate them.

Q6

What is the correct way to finish and deliver the composite?

B) Save the layered .psd master, then File ► Export ► Export As a JPG

Why: the master stays fully editable; Export As flattens the JPG automatically. Flattening and saving over the .psd (A) throws away every layer.

LAB REFERENCE: GROUND, DEPTH, GRADE (MODULE 4 DELIVERABLE)

A correct result: two shadow layers *below* the SUBJECT: **Contact Shadow** (small, darkest at the feet, unblurred) and **Cast Shadow** (longer, softer, blurred, falling the same way as the scene's shadows; on **L12-scene-sunset.jpg** and **L13-scene-hard-sun.jpg** that is toward the left). Optional haze layer for a distant subject. One unclipped grade (Color Lookup or Curves) plus a soft vignette at the top. A layered .psd and an exported JPG. At a squint, the subject reads as standing *on* the ground, not hovering in front of it.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Subject still floats:** no contact shadow, or it is too light or too far from the feet.
- ◆ **Shadow points the wrong way:** the learner didn't check the scene's existing shadows first.
- ◆ **A gray blob shadow:** uniform opacity and softness; it should fade and soften along its length.
- ◆ **Contact point looks fuzzy:** Gaussian Blur was applied to the contact layer, or both shadows were painted on one layer.
- ◆ **Shadows show on top of the subject:** shadow layers were created above the SUBJECT group. Drag them below.
- ◆ **Obvious fog or heavy color cast:** haze or grade too strong. Both should be subtle; if the grade is doing the heavy lifting, revisit the L12 match.
- ◆ **Only a flattened file exists:** the master was flattened. Recover from the last layered save if possible; reinforce Save first, then Export As.

Module 5 — Answers & Lab Notes

Every workbook self-check answered and explained, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 14–16

18 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks are numbered Q1–Q6 within each lesson, so a learner's "L15 Q4" is always this key's L15 Q4. Every answer is taken from what the lesson teaches.

L14 • TYPE & HIERARCHY

Q1

Which kind of type should you use for a big poster title?

A) Point type (a single click)

Why: point type is for short display lines. Paragraph type is a poor fit for a title: if the box is too small the overflow is hidden, and resizing the box doesn't scale the letters. So they don't behave the same (C).

Q2

What does leading control?

B) The space between lines of text

Why: leading is between lines; kerning is between one specific pair of letters (A); tracking is even spacing across a word or line. Letter thickness (C) is weight.

Q3

A small all-caps label like "TICKETS AT THE DOOR" looks cramped. What's the fix from the lesson?

C) Add positive tracking

Why: loosening tracking on small all-caps labels makes them feel deliberate and elegant. Tightening leading (B) is for big multi-line headlines.

Q4

What is the most common fix on a beginner poster?

A) Make the main line much bigger

Why: weak hierarchy is the most common beginner mistake. If the 1st and 2nd lines are close in size, the hierarchy is too weak. More fonts (B) or accents everywhere (C) scatter the eye.

Q5

How many fonts does the lesson recommend on one poster?

B) One or two

Why: one characterful display font for the title and one clean font for everything else. Create contrast through size and weight, not a "font circus."

Q6

Your text on a circular path is upside down along the bottom. What do you do?

C) Drag across the path with the Path Selection tool to flip it, then reposition

Why: this is normal behavior. The Path Selection tool flips text to the inside or the other side of the path and slides it along the curve.

LAB REFERENCE: FIX THE HIERARCHY

A correct result: `poster-working.psd` at 18 × 24 in, 150 ppi, dark background, with one type layer per line. The title (for the practice copy: SUMMER / MUSIC FESTIVAL) is dramatically larger than anything else, with tightened leading so its lines read as a unit. The date and place line is clearly second (the natural home for the single accent color, or a small "tickets" badge). Details are smaller; the fine print is smallest, in tracked all-caps. One or two fonts. At least one element (an arc or a circular badge stamp such as "EST · 2026 · LIVE") uses type on a path. A viewer names the reading order correctly at a glance.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **All lines similar in size:** timidity. Scale the 1st line up until it feels too big.
- ◆ **All text on one layer:** the learner kept clicking inside existing text. Commit, then click empty canvas.
- ◆ **Title cut off:** paragraph type in a too-small box. Retype it as point type.
- ◆ **Three to five fonts, accent on everything:** variety in place of hierarchy. Back to two fonts, one accent.
- ◆ **Type on a path missing:** usually the Ellipse tool was left in Shape mode, or the Type tool clicked beside the path rather than on it (wait for the wavy cursor).

Q1

Why does a vector shape stay crisp when you enlarge it?

B) It is stored as math (instructions) and redrawn fresh at any size

Why: a raster image is a grid of pixels, and enlarging it has no new pixels to show. A vector ("a circle of this radius here") is recomputed at the new size, from a stamp to a stadium banner.

Q2

What is the Pen's "two-move rule"?

A) Click for corners; click and drag for curves

Why: clicking drops a corner anchor; click-and-drag drops a smooth anchor and pulls out handles that shape the curve. That is about 90% of the Pen; adding, deleting, and converting points is tidying up.

Q3

Your Pen curve looks lumpy. What's the most likely cause?

C) Too many anchor points

Why: smooth curves need surprisingly few points: one wherever the curve changes direction. Also check that handles run roughly tangent to the curve.

Q4

You draw a closed shape with the Pen set to Path mode. Where does it appear?

B) As a Work Path in the Paths panel, not as a new layer

Why: Shape mode makes a shape layer; Path mode makes a path you can then turn into a selection, a filled area, a stroke, or a vector mask (right-click with the Pen active).

Q5

How do you prove a shape layer stays sharp and a rasterized copy doesn't?

A) Scale both up about 400% with Ctrl/⌘+T and compare at 100% zoom

Why: just zooming in (B) won't show it, because Photoshop displays both as screen pixels at high zoom. The difference appears when you actually resize: the shape stays razor sharp; the raster copy goes soft.

Q6

To subtract a small circle from your badge on the same shape layer, when do you choose Subtract Front Shape?

C) With the badge layer active, before drawing the second shape

Why: Path Operations are set before you draw the next shape (or hold Alt/⌘ as you start dragging to subtract). With the default New Layer setting, the second shape lands on its own layer instead.

LAB REFERENCE: VECTOR ELEMENTS

A correct result: in the Layers panel, shape layers (one thumbnail with a small shape badge) for: a frame (Fill: none, a few-pixel stroke in the accent color); a badge made from combined shapes on a single layer (for example a ring, from Subtract Front Shape), with the L14 type on a path around it; one custom Pen shape (mountain, soundwave, or leaf) with few anchor points and smooth curves. A Work Path in the Paths panel (or a vector mask) shows a path was reused, for example as a selection turned into a layer mask. Side by side after a 400% scale, the shape is crisp and the rasterized copy is soft. On `l15-pen-practice.png`, good tracings land close to the marked point counts.

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Nothing in Layers after drawing:** the Pen was in Path mode. Check the Paths panel, or switch to Shape.
- ◆ **A solid rectangle covering the poster:** Fill wasn't set to none.
- ◆ **Badge on two layers:** Path Operations chosen after drawing, or left on New Layer.
- ◆ **Lumpy, wobbly Pen shape with 30+ points:** dragged like a brush or clicked everywhere. Redo with the two-move rule.
- ◆ **Both copies look identical after "the test":** the learner only zoomed in instead of scaling with Ctrl/⌘+T.
- ◆ **Pixel-painted shapes:** the Shape tool was in Pixels mode; the result is raster and won't scale cleanly.

L16 · LAYER STYLES & THE POSTER

Q1

What is a layer style?

C) A set of live, re-editable effects attached to the layer

Why: effects live on the layer rather than being painted into it; change the text or recolor the shape and they re-render. Nothing is baked in, so (A) is wrong.

Q2

How do you reuse the exact look of one styled layer on another?

A) Right-click its fx ► Copy Layer Style, then right-click the other layer ► Paste Layer Style

Why: reusing styles keeps the poster consistent, and consistency is what makes a design feel intentional. Merging (B) destroys the separate layers.

Q3

Which title treatment does the lesson recommend?

B) Gradient Overlay + a subtle Drop Shadow

Why: restraint beats effects. A tasteful poster usually uses a gradient and a soft shadow. Stacks of bevels and glows (A) read as amateur and dated.

Q4

You're exporting the poster for social media. Which settings are right?

A) RGB, JPG or PNG, pixel dimensions that fit the platform

Why: screens are RGB, and on screen the ppi number doesn't matter, only pixel dimensions. CMYK at 300 ppi as a PDF/X (B) is the print route.

Q5

Your printer wants 0.125 in of bleed. Photoshop has no bleed setting. How do you add it?

C) Image ► Canvas Size to add it on every side, then extend the background into it

Why: you build the bleed into the canvas. Keep type well inside the trim, not at the edges (B). Export As (A) has no bleed option.

Q6

After scaling a layer down, its stroke and shadow look too heavy. What fixes it?

B) Right-click the fx ► Scale Effects (or adjust the values by hand)

Why: transforming a layer doesn't resize its effects; they keep their pixel values. Scale Effects (also Layer ► Layer Style ► Scale Effects) resizes them to match. Image ► Image Size scales them only when Scale Styles is ticked.

LAB REFERENCE: FINISH THE POSTER (MODULE 5 DELIVERABLE)

A correct result: the title shows an fx badge with Gradient Overlay (two tones of the accent) and a soft, low-opacity Drop Shadow that lifts it gently off the page. The badge has a Stroke and soft shadow, and the same style appears on at least one other element (pasted). The sponsor logo (`l16-sponsor-logo.png` or the learner's own) is a Smart Object; a hero image (`l16-hero-stage.jpg` or the learner's Module 4 composite) sits behind the type as a Smart Object via Place Embedded. No layer carries more than two or three effects. Margins are even; the hierarchy from L14 still reads at a squint. The layered .psd is intact and a screen JPG has been exported. (Homework print version: canvas enlarged by the bleed on every side with the background extended, type inside the trim, CMYK conversion on a copy or via the printer's PDF/X preset, saved with File ► Save a Copy as Photoshop PDF.)

Common wrong results and why:

- ◆ **Hard, black, far-offset shadow:** default-ish values pushed up. Lower opacity, reduce distance, raise size a little.
- ◆ **Bevel, glow, stroke, and shadow on everything:** effect enthusiasm. Remove until each remaining effect has a job.
- ◆ **Soft, jaggy logo:** pasted as pixels and scaled up. Re-place it with File ► Place Embedded as a Smart Object.
- ◆ **Inconsistent badges:** each styled by hand. Copy/Paste Layer Style.
- ◆ **Hero image hides the type:** layer order. The photo goes at the bottom, above the background only.
- ◆ **Poster exported in CMYK for social, or colors look dull online:** the print route was used for screen. Screen = RGB JPG.
- ◆ **Only a flattened file exists:** the master was flattened. Reinforce: the .psd is the master, always.

Module 6: Answers & Lab Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for each lab: what a correct result looks like, and the common wrong results and why they happen.

Lessons 17-19

16 quiz items

3 hands-on labs

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "L18 Q3" is always this key's L18 Q3.

L17 • GENERATIVE FILL

Q1

What is the basic Generative Fill workflow?

B) Select an area, then describe what should be there

Why: The selection is the "where" and the prompt is the "what." Photoshop reads the surrounding image for context and generates content to fit the selection. There is no generative brush, and the prompt never decides placement on its own.

Q2

You want to remove a sign from the shoreline. After selecting it, what do you do?

C) Leave the prompt empty and click Generate

Why: An empty prompt tells Photoshop to fill with plausible background. Typing "sign" would ask it to *generate* a sign; pressing Delete leaves a hole or flat color.

Q3

Where does a Generative Fill result go?

A) On a new generative layer with its own mask

Why: The original pixels are never touched. You can hide, mask, lower the opacity of, delete, or stack another generation on the result: it is one more non-destructive layer.

Q4

Which prompt is most likely to work well?

B) "a wooden park bench"

Why: Short and concrete wins. A vague prompt gives Photoshop nothing to build; a long stylistic one fights the scene's existing light. Name the object and let Photoshop match the lighting.

Q5

Every lighthouse variation comes out short and squat. What should you change first?

C) Make a taller selection

Why: Generative Fill fills the shape you give it, so the selection's size and proportion strongly steer the result. "Selecting the right space is half the prompt."

LAB REFERENCE: REMOVE & ADD

Correct result: `generative-working.psd` with the untouched original at the bottom and at least two generative layers above it: one from an empty prompt (the distraction is gone, background continues believably) and one from a described prompt (a new element that sits in the scene's light and perspective). At least one refine move is visible: a painted mask edge, a clipped Curves or Hue/Saturation, or a healing layer. At 100% there are no obvious ghosts or smears.

Common wrong results: **Halo or ghost outline where the object was:** the selection hugged the object; redo with a looser selection. **Blurry, mushy fill:** the selection was too large; generate in smaller pieces. **New element too bright or wrong color:** not refined; clip an adjustment to the generative layer. **Only one layer in the file, or edits on the Background:** learner used Content-Aware Fill or the Remove tool on the photo itself, not Generative Fill (acceptable only under the offline fallback, and then it should be on a separate layer). **Garbled hands or text:** an expected limit, not a learner error; use it as a teaching moment.

Offline fallback version: removal done with the Remove tool or Content-Aware Fill on a separate layer (Sample All Layers on), no "add" step. Grade it on the same checklist minus the variation and prompt items.

L18 · GENERATIVE EXPAND & REFRAME

Q1

What is Generative Expand, really?

A) Generative Fill aimed at empty canvas around the photo

Why: Enlarging the canvas leaves empty space, and Photoshop generates scenery to continue the photo into it. Same generative layer, same variations, same optional prompt. Nothing is stretched or upsampled.

Q2

You chose Ratio 16:9 and pressed Enter, and Photoshop cropped your photo smaller. What did you skip?

C) Dragging the crop handles outward past the photo

Why: A ratio only sets the shape. Photoshop first fits that shape *inside* the photo, which is a normal crop. You must drag outward until the box extends past the edges (the ratio stays locked while you drag).

Q3

One big expansion came out vague and repetitive. What is the better approach?

B) Expand in smaller steps, generating each time

Why: Huge single expansions spread the generated detail thin. Several smaller expansions stay close to real pixels and look far better. A short prompt can also give the fill something specific to build.

Q4

What is the fastest giveaway of a bad expand?

B) A horizon or strong line that jumps at the seam

Why: The eye follows lines. If the horizon runs straight through, most viewers never suspect the edges were invented. Check it first, at 100%.

Q5

What does an empty prompt do in Generative Expand?

A) Continues the existing scene into the new space

Why: Just like removal in L17, an empty prompt means "fill with what belongs here." A short prompt ("open sky," "a calm beach") steers the new area instead. Filling with the background color is what Fill: Background does, not Generative Expand.

LAB REFERENCE: UNCROP & REFRAME

Correct result: `expand-working.psd` whose canvas is larger than the original photo, with the new margins on generative layer(s) and the original pixels intact. The subject has breathing room; the document has a useful ratio (16:9, 1:1, 4:5, or 9:16); the subject's proportions are unchanged (circles stay round). At 100%, the horizon and any strong lines run continuously across the join, and a subtle clipped Curves or unifying grade makes old and new read as one image. With `l18-horizon-strip.jpg` the horizon should stay dead level and the diagonal fence should continue on the same angle.

Common wrong results: **Photo got smaller:** ratio chosen but handles not dragged outward. **Flat white or black margins:** Fill was left on Background. **Subject looks wider or squashed:** Free Transform or Image Size was used instead of Expand. **Repeated clouds, trees, or rocks in the margin:** one huge leap; redo in bites. **Visible step in the horizon:** accepted the first variation; cycle variations or regenerate a thin strip across the seam with Generative Fill. **Slight brightness or color shift at the join:** skipped the unifying grade.

Offline fallback version: Crop tool dragged outward with Fill: Content-Aware Fill. Expect weaker results on large expansions; grade the workflow (outward drag, bites, seam check) rather than the fill quality.

L19 · ACTIONS, BATCH & DROPLETS

Q1

What is an Action?

B) A recording of steps you can replay with one click

Why: You press record, do the task once, and press stop; Photoshop remembers every step. Scripts (JavaScript) are code, a separate and more advanced tool; tool presets store settings for one tool.

Q2

Why record Fit Image instead of Image Size?

C) Fit Image fits the long edge on landscape and portrait files alike

Why: Fit Image 1200 × 1200 px makes the longer side 1200 whatever the orientation. Image Size records a fixed width, so a portrait file would come out 1200 wide and far taller than intended. Record general steps that work on any file.

Q3

Every batched file was saved into the recording folder instead of the Destination. What was missed?

A) Ticking Override Action "Save As" Commands

Why: The Action contains its own Save As step. Without the override, Batch obeys the recorded save location instead of the Destination you chose.

Q4

While recording, Save As does not offer JPEG. Which step belongs before it?

C) Layer ► Flatten Image

Why: After Place Embedded, the file has an extra (watermark) layer. Current Photoshop only offers JPEG in Save As for a file without extra layers, so flattening must be a recorded step before saving.

Q5

sRGB web JPGs of a whole shoot, with no recording. Which tool?

B) Image Processor

Why: File ► Scripts ► Image Processor resizes and saves a folder to JPG, PSD, or TIFF in one go, optionally running an Action. Batch needs an Action; a droplet is an Action saved as an app.

Q6

What is a droplet?

A) An Action saved as a drag-and-drop app

Why: File ► Automate ► Create Droplet saves an Action as a small app. Drag files or a folder onto it and they process; it launches Photoshop itself (which must be installed).

LAB REFERENCE: RECORD & BATCH

Correct result: an Actions panel showing Set "Export Web" containing Action "Web JPG 1200" with these steps: Convert to Profile (sRGB), Fit Image (1200 × 1200 px), Place (the watermark), Flatten Image, Save (JPEG), Close. The `119-processed/` folder holds one JPEG per input file, each with a long edge of 1200 px (landscape 1200 wide, portrait 1200 tall, square 1200 × 1200), the watermark in a consistent position, and sRGB. The `119-input/` folder is unchanged. A droplet file exists on the desktop and processes files dropped onto it.

Common wrong results: **Portrait outputs 1200 wide and ~1600 tall:** Image Size was recorded instead of Fit Image. **Outputs missing, or in the wrong folder:** Override Action "Save As" Commands not ticked. **Batch stopped after a few files:** a warning dialog (missing profile) halted it; tick Suppress color profile warnings and log errors to a file. **Watermark in a different spot on portrait files:** position depends on canvas size; acceptable for this lab if it is fully on the canvas, a good discussion of "record on a typical image, test on an odd one." **Small file enlarged to 1200 and soft** (`119-batch-07.jpg`): Fit Image enlarges by default; point out the Don't Enlarge option in the Fit Image dialog. **Extra steps like "Select" or "Move" in the Action:** the learner kept recording while exploring; delete those steps. **Originals overwritten:** Destination pointed at the input folder; restore from the practice folder and discuss why copies matter.

Module 7: Answers & Capstone Notes

Self-check answers with explanations, plus reference notes for the three capstone stages: what a solid plan, build, and presentation look like, and the common weak results and why they happen.

Lessons 20-22

15 quiz items

1 capstone, 3 stages

NUMBERING MATCHES THE WORKBOOK

The participant workbook's self-checks use the same question numbers as this key, so a learner's "L21 Q3" is always this key's L21 Q3.

L20 • CHOOSE YOUR BRIEF & PLAN

Q1

Which three questions should you answer before opening Photoshop?

A) What is it for? Who is it for? What does "done" look like?

Why: Purpose sets every later decision; the audience shapes tone and the destination sets size, resolution, and color mode; defining "done" up front tells you when to stop. Tools, fonts, and layer counts are downstream choices.

Q2

Which of these is a complete one-line brief?

B) "A gig poster for a local band, to be seen printed on a wall, that feels loud, retro, and warm."

Why: It fills every slot of the template: what (gig poster), who (a local band's audience), where (printed on a wall), and three adjectives. A is a vague wish; C is document settings, not a brief.

Q3

What belongs on a quick moodboard?

A) A palette of 3 to 5 colors, one or two fonts, and a rough layout sketch

Why: The moodboard's only job is to make you decide mood, palette, and layout before the canvas does. Rough is fine; scribbles count.

Q4

Your piece is a poster to be printed. How do you set up the document?

B) The Print preset at real-world size, 300 ppi, converting to CMYK for the printer at export

Why: Print needs real-world size at 300 ppi. The course designs in RGB and converts to the printer's CMYK profile at export (Module 5). A 72 ppi web document would print soft; "fix it later" means upscaling or rebuilding.

Q5

How ambitious should your capstone be?

B) One notch beyond what you have done, not ten

Why: A finished, polished piece at 80% of your dream idea beats an abandoned masterpiece. Repeating something already made teaches little; the epic version can come next.

REFERENCE: A SOLID PLAN

Looks like: a one-line brief with all four slots filled; a clear definition of "done"; 5 to 10 references with a note on what each contributes; 3 to 5 palette colors; one or two fonts; a thumbnail layout that shows the focal point, title, and supporting info; a skill map of specific moves tagged by module (e.g. "cut out subject (M4), match light (M4), type hierarchy (M5), grade (M2)"); and a document whose size, resolution, and color mode match the destination. The partner's answer to "What do you expect this to look like?" roughly matches the brief.

Common weak plans: Adjectives missing or generic ("nice, cool, good"): nothing to steer decisions; ask "how should a viewer feel?" **Three fonts or eight colors:** Module 5's rule is one or two fonts; trim. **Skill map says "Photoshop stuff":** ask for moves, not topics. **Scope for a series** (three posters, a full brand system): scale to one piece plus, at most, one variation. **Web-sized document for a print piece:** rebuild the document now, before any work goes into it.

L21 · STUDIO SESSION: BUILD IT WELL

Q1

What is the right build order for a big piece?

B) Block in the composition roughly, then refine big to small

Why: Time spent perfecting an eyelash before the composition is decided is time you will throw away. Only once the big shapes work do details deserve attention.

Q2

How do you give a layer group a color label?

A) Right-click the group's eye (visibility) icon and pick a color

Why: That is the lesson's method. Renaming is done by double-clicking the group name; double-clicking a thumbnail does something else (for example, opens a Smart Object's contents).

Q3

Which statement about History snapshots is true?

B) History clears when you close the file, snapshots included, so you should also save versioned files

Why: Snapshots are session-only restore points. Versioned saves (`capstone_v1.psd` , `_v2`) protect you across sessions and crashes.

Q4

What does View ► Flip Horizontal do?

B) Flips only the view, so you see the piece with fresh eyes

Why: It changes only how the canvas is displayed, so there is nothing to undo; choose it again to flip back. Fresh eyes catch imbalances familiar eyes miss.

Q5

Your capstone file is huge and slow. What is the safe first move?

A) Save a full layered version, then merge or flatten finished sections in a working copy

Why: You keep an editable master and gain speed in the copy. Flattening the master destroys editability. Converting groups to Smart Objects tidies the stack but usually does not shrink the file, because the layers are kept inside. Edit ► Purge also helps if history is eating memory.

REFERENCE: A WELL-BUILT CAPSTONE FILE

Looks like: a `capstone_final.psd` master plus at least one earlier version on disk; top-level groups named by role (BACKGROUND, SUBJECT, TYPE, GRADE or similar) and color-labeled; no "Layer 12 copy 3"; adjustments on adjustment layers, placed photos as Smart Objects, and edits controlled by masks; a unifying grade at the top of the stack. The image meets the strong-piece rubric: a clear focal point, consistent light and color, clean edges and masks at 100%, deliberate type (if any), and no distracting artifacts.

Brief-specific checks: **Poster:** one dominant title, clear hierarchy, type inside the trim. **Surreal composite:** shadows and light direction agree; grain and color match across elements. **Retouched portrait:** skin texture kept (heal, don't erase), no plastic look, dodge & burn subtle. **Restoration:** scratches and dust gone without smudged detail; tone and color balanced; the result still looks like the original era. **Product hero shot:** clean cutout, a believable contact shadow, a background that supports rather than competes. **Brand mini-kit:** a logo lockup built from shapes and type; social pieces share fonts, palette, and layout via Smart Objects.

Common weak results: **Flat, unnamed stack:** organized "later" (never). **Painted-in edits on the photo layer:** destructive habits returned under pressure; ask them to rebuild the one key edit non-destructively. **Halo or fringe around a cutout:** skipped the 100% pass. **Two focal points competing:** no step-back; squint test reveals it. **Elements with different light:** no match or unifying grade. **Over-scoped and half-finished:** agree a minimum presentable version and hide unfinished elements.

L22 · PRESENT & SHIP

Q1

Your piece will be shown on screens. What do you deliver?

B) A JPG or PNG in sRGB, keeping the layered .psd master safe

Why: Screens need a flat file in sRGB (PNG if transparency is needed). The .psd is the editable master, never the delivery. A CMYK PDF with bleed is the print delivery, to the printer's spec.

Q2

How do you put your art into a mockup template?

A) Double-click the Smart Object layer's thumbnail, place your art in the .psb tab, save, and close it

Why: Mockups are built around a Smart Object. Editing its contents and saving updates the mockup, which warps the art to fit the scene. Pasting on top loses the warp and lighting; flattening destroys the template.

Q3

What goes in the two-sentence artist statement?

B) What it is and who it is for, then one interesting decision you made and why

Why: Sentence one orients the viewer; sentence two shows your thinking. Tool lists bore viewers, and apologies undercut the work before anyone has seen it.

Q4

The rubric's "Believability" row asks...

A) Do shadows agree on one light? Any telltale AI artifacts?

Why: Believability is about whether the image could be real. Font count belongs to the Type row; file size is not a rubric item.

Q5

"Done is a decision" means...

B) Use the rubric to decide the piece is finished, then ship it

Why: No piece is ever perfect. The rubric lets you call it finished with confidence; shipping a good piece today beats polishing a slightly better one forever.

REFERENCE: A SHIPPED CAPSTONE

Looks like: a delivery file named clearly and sized for its destination (sRGB JPG/PNG for screen; for print, a 300 ppi CMYK PDF with bleed to the printer's spec, plus a screen JPG for the class projector); the art shown in at least one context mockup with a soft shadow; a before/after or process image; a two-sentence statement in the "what and who, then one decision and why" pattern; the layered master saved separately. Generative content is disclosed where honesty matters.

Common weak results: **Delivered the .psd** or a CMYK JPG for screen (colors look off): re-export in sRGB. **Art pasted flat over the mockup:** did not edit the Smart Object, so no warp or lighting. **Mockup without a shadow:** looks pasted on. **Statement that lists tools or apologizes:** rewrite in the two-sentence pattern. **Rubric self-score all "strong"** with visible halos: ask them to zoom to 100% on the edges row.

CRITIQUE QUALITY: WHAT GOOD PEER FEEDBACK SOUNDS LIKE

Strong: "The first thing I notice is the red title. What confused me was the second figure on the left. On Light & color: the warm grade really sells the summer-night feel (glow). I wonder if the figure's shadow could fall to the right like the others (grow)." **Weak:** "I love it." (not specific) · "I'd have made it blue." (taste, not the brief) · "The whole thing doesn't work." (not actionable). Coach weak feedback toward a rubric row and a pointable spot on screen.